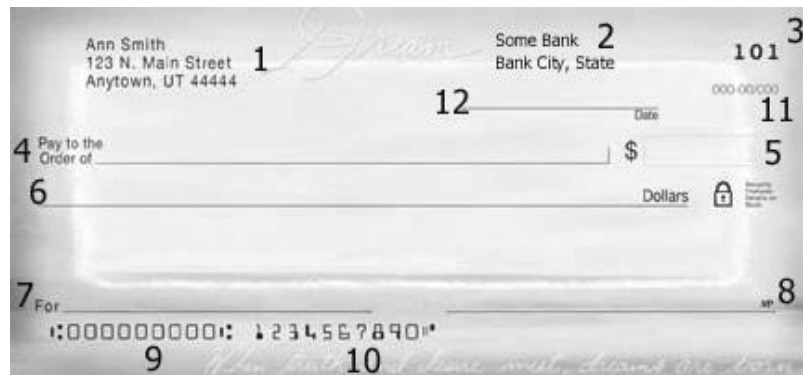


How to Read a Check

Wondering how to read a check, understand the check format, and review the individual parts that make up a typical check?

- What are the different areas of a check?
- How do I read the MICR line? The Federal Reserve requires a person's account number, routing number, and check number to be printed in MICR (magnetic ink character recognition) ink or toner. MICR is a type of magnetic ink that verifies the legitimacy of a check.⁵⁵

The example below is a personal check. Each numbered section is defined below.



Section 1: Account holder's name, address, phone number, and email address can appear in this section of the check, called the *Address Field*.

Section 2: The bank name, city and state of the processing facility, or the city and state of the account holder's branch; the bank's phone number; the bank's website address and/or the bank's email address may appear in this section. This section can also be located above field 7 (the memo field).

Section 3: *The check number* appears at the top right, shown here as 101.

⁵⁵ "What is MICR?" *TechTarget*, 20201. <https://searchsecurity.techtarget.com/definition/MICR>

Section 4: *Pay to the order of.* This section should have the name of the person or company that is being paid (the name of the party receiving the check).

Section 5: The amount written *numerically*. If this check were for one hundred dollars, within the box labeled "5" in the example above, it should read, "\$100.00."

Section 6: The amount written *in words*. If this check were for \$100, in the blank section labeled "6," you would write, "One Hundred and 00/100." Many people will then draw a line to the preprinted "Dollars" to discourage alteration. If the check were for \$101.59, it would be written, "One Hundred One and 59/100."

Section 7: The "For" or "Memo" section can be left blank, or you can enter any information about the payment. Some people note an account number or invoice number that is being paid with the check, others may just write, "For Birthday" or another note to remind them what the check was for. This field is not read by the bank and does not change how the check is processed.

Section 8: *The signature line.* This is where the account holder would sign the check. On a check draft, the signature is not required, although it is common to have a signature disclaimer in this section.

Section 9: This MICR field is the **routing number**. This is the 9 digit code that routes the check to the issuing bank. The routing number should match the bank name and the fraction code. This number is needed when providing direct deposit information to an employer.

Section 10: The **account number**. This is an MICR field that lists the account holder's account number at the bank. This number is also needed when providing direct deposit information to an employer.

Section 11: *Fraction Code.* This field is the fraction that denotes the routing for the check. The fraction code is another way to write the 9-digit routing number. If the MICR line on the check is mutilated, the fraction code will be used in its place.

Section 12: The date field. Fill this in with the date the check is created.⁵⁶

⁵⁶ "How to read a check." *CheckWriter*, 2021. <http://checkwriter.net/how-to-read-a-check.htm>